

Oh Canada — Daily Itinerary

Summer 2026 · Jun 25 – Jul 7 · road trip from Evanston, IL

Parents' copy — full logistics + confirmations + emergency info + nature & safety

At a glance — stays & confirmations

DATES	STAY	DRIVE	SITE	IN / OUT	CONF.
Jun 25	Brunet Island SP, Cornell, WI	~5 hr · 290 mi	#39	3p / 1p	INWI26-1293044B1
Jun 26	Bear Head Lake SP, Ely, MN	~4 hr · 210 mi	#2	— ¹	#12635093
Jun 27	Sioux Narrows PP, ON	~5 hr · 230 mi	#27	2p / 2p	INOP26-4271890B1
Jun 28 – Jul 2	Tom & Carol's Cottage, Victoria Beach, MB	~3.5 hr · 250 km	5 nts	—	—
Jul 3	Zippel Bay SP, Williams, MN	~4 hr · 250 km	Anglers #48	— ¹	#12639147
Jul 4	Gooseberry Falls SP, Two Harbors, MN	~4.5 hr · 250 mi	#68	— ¹	#12637943
Jul 5	Brule River State Forest, Brule, WI	~1.5 hr · 75 mi	Brule Cmpgd	3p / 1p	INWI26-1743772B1
Jul 6	Mirror Lake SP, Baraboo, WI	~4 hr · 240 mi	—	3p / 1p	INWI26-1744723B1
Jul 7	→ Home, Evanston, IL	~2.5 hr · 170 mi	—	—	—

MN parks: state permit #12658950 covers Bear Head, Zippel Bay & Gooseberry. Distances in **mi** on US legs / **km** on Canada legs. ¹ **Check-in/out:** WI parks 3 PM in / 1 PM out; Ontario 2 PM in/out; MN parks post no fixed clock time but hold your reserved site until 11 AM the day after arrival. Sunsets run late up north — daylight to ~9:10 PM (Northwoods/North Shore) and ~9:35 PM (Victoria Beach, MB), with usable light until ~10 PM.

⚠ Trip safety — read once before you go

Blue-green algae (the #1 dog danger): Lake Winnipeg (and other warm lakes) bloom with toxic cyanobacteria in summer. **A tiny amount can kill a dog within hours — there is no antidote.** If water looks like pea soup, spilled paint, or has a blue-green scum, keep the dog out and don't let him drink lake water near shore.

Lake Superior: ~40°F year-round → cold-water shock in minutes, plus rip currents that drown people every year. Treat it like an ocean: wade, don't swim out; no one in the water during wind/wave warnings.

Ticks & Lyme: WI/MN northwoods are among the highest Lyme/anaplasmosis areas in the country. Repellent, long pants in brush, and a full tick check (people + dog) every night.

Bears & moose: store all food/scented items in the car (never the tent); keep distance. Moose injure more people than bears — never get between a cow and her calf.

Dawn/dusk driving: moose and deer on the road are a real collision risk on the northern legs — slow down at low light, especially Ely → Sioux Narrows and the Canada legs.

Plants: poison ivy is everywhere; **wild parsnip** (yellow roadside flower) sap + sun causes blistering burns; never let kids chew unknown plants near water (**water hemlock**, the most poisonous plant in North America, grows in wet ditches here).

Bugs & water critters: mosquitoes and black flies peak in late June; leeches and "swimmer's itch" turn up in warm shallow lakes (rinse/towel off after swimming).

Weather & signal: prairie and Great-Lakes storms blow up fast — check radar. Cell signal is spotty around Ely/Boundary Waters, the Shield near Sioux Narrows, and the Whiteshell; download offline maps + this page.

📍 Emergency & practical

24-hr vet — MN Northwoods/North Shore: [BluePearl Pet Hospital](#), 2314 W Michigan St, Duluth · (218) 302-8000 (open 24h)

24-hr vet — Canada leg (ON + MB): [Winnipeg Animal Emergency Hospital](#) · (204) 474-0298 (open 24h)

24-hr vet — Wisconsin Dells leg: nearest is Madison — [UW Veterinary Care](#) · (608) 263-7600, or VEG Madison (walk-in 24/7)

Park offices: Brunet Island (715) 239-6888 · Bear Head Lake (218) 235-2520 · Zippel Bay (218) 783-6252 · Gooseberry Falls (218) 595-7100 · Mirror Lake (608) 254-2333

Spotty/no cell signal: Bear Head Lake & the Ely/Boundary Waters area, stretches of the Canadian Shield near Sioux Narrows, and parts of the Whiteshell. Download offline maps + this page before those legs.

Border crossings & pets

Two crossings: into Canada **Sat Jun 27** (International Falls → Fort Frances); back to the US **Fri Jul 3** (Sprague → Warroad/Roseau). Have everyone's **passports** out and reachable.

Dog — into Canada: Canada requires a **valid rabies vaccination certificate** (in English/French, signed by your vet, identifying the dog) for dogs over 3 months. Bring the paper copy with the microchip number on it.

Dog — back into the US: since Aug 2024 the CDC requires a free **CDC Dog Import Form** for every dog (must be 6+ months and microchipped). Fill it out online a few days before Jul 3 — you'll get a receipt (valid 6 months) to show or print. Keep the rabies certificate handy too.

Don't carry across: no fresh produce, plants, or raw meat either direction — and **no firewood** (buy it at each park; moving it spreads tree-killing pests). Declare any alcohol/tobacco.

Fuel & cash: top off US-side before crossing (cheaper, and gas thins out in Ontario); a little Canadian cash helps at the cottage-area stores.

Thu, Jun 25 — Home → Brunet Island State Park, WI

~5 hr (≈290 mi), I-90/94

Fuel/snacks: Kwik Trips near Tomah or Eau Claire

Lunch + cool stop: Norske Nook, Osseo — legendary award-winning Norwegian pie right off I-94. Grab a slice (or whole pie) for the road.

Dinner (takeout): Moonridge Brewing Co., Cornell — specialty pizzas + brews, dog-friendly patio. Backup: Sam's Place & Diner.

Wild Things — Chippewa River country

- **Beaver:** second-biggest rodent on Earth; orange front teeth are iron-coated and **never stop growing**. **Gross:** marks territory with **castoreum**, a goo squeezed from sacs next to the butt that smells like vanilla — once used in perfume and food flavoring.
- **River otter:** holds its breath ~8 min; the whole family shares one bathroom spot on the bank called a "**latrine**."
- **Bald eagle:** builds the biggest tree nest of any N. American bird (up to 2 tons).
Darker side: it's a scavenger and a thief — it dive-bombs ospreys to rob their fish and rips into rotting deer carcasses and roadkill.
- **Lake sturgeon:** a living fossil, armored in bony plates, can live 100+ years and top 6 feet, vacuuming food off the river bottom.

⚠ Heads-up — Chippewa Valley

- **Ticks & Lyme:** first night in northwoods brush — repellent + a full tick check on everyone (and the dog) before bed.
- **Wild parsnip** lines these roadsides (tall yellow flower); its sap + sunlight = blistering chemical burns. Look, don't touch.
- Poison ivy along the river trails — "leaves of three, let it be."

Did you know? — Chippewa Valley, WI

- Cornell has the **world's only surviving "pulpwood stacker"** — a 175-foot tower built in 1912 to pile logs for a paper mill.
- Nearby Chippewa Falls is home to **Leinenkugel's**, the 7th-oldest brewery in the U.S. (1867), and the birthplace of **Seymour Cray**, the "father of the supercomputer."
- Wisconsin is the **"Badger State"** — named not for the animal but for 1800s lead miners who dug into hillsides like badgers.

- You'll follow the **Chippewa River**, one of the longest rivers entirely inside Wisconsin.

Brunet Island SP, Site #39 · conf INWI26-1293044B1

Fri, Jun 26 — Brunet Island → Bear Head Lake State Park, MN

~4 hr (≈210 mi) through Duluth

Fuel/snacks: top off in Duluth (last big Kwik Trip cluster before the Northwoods)

Lunch + cool stop: Duluth Canal Park — eat with a Lake Superior view + the Aerial Lift Bridge; quick add-on is Enger Tower.

Dinner (takeout): Junction Bar & Grill, Babbitt (~10 min from camp), or pick up in Ely.

Cool stop near camp (Ely): International Wolf Center & North American Bear Center — both highly rated.

Wild Things — Northwoods & Boundary Waters

- **Gray wolf:** smells prey 1.5+ miles off and gulps ~20 lbs of meat at once ("wolfing it down"). **Gross:** parents swallow meat, trot to the den, and **vomit it back up** for the pups; scat is full of hair and bone. **Darker side:** a pack kills by running prey to exhaustion and often starts eating the gut and organs before the animal is dead.
- **Moose:** largest deer alive; eats 40–60 lbs of plants a day and **dives fully underwater** (nostrils closed) to feed off the lake bottom. The flap under its throat is a "**bell**."
- **Black bear:** eats up to 20,000 calories/day before winter, then dens for months without eating, drinking, peeing, or pooping — a hard "**fecal plug**" seals its rear all winter. Nose ~7× a bloodhound's.
- **Common loon:** solid (not hollow) bones let it dive 200 ft; legs set so far back it needs a **quarter-mile water "runway"** to take off; swallows pebbles to grind fish in its gut.

⚠ Heads-up — bear & moose country, cold lake

- **Bear protocol at camp:** all food, trash, and scented items locked in the car — never in the tent. A fed bear is a dangerous bear.
- **Moose > bears for injuries:** give any moose a very wide berth, especially a cow with a calf; back away if ears pin back or hackles rise.
- Lake Superior at Duluth/Canal Park: ~40°F, cold-water shock and rip currents — kids and dog stay out of the surf.
- Dusk drive into Ely: peak moose/deer-on-road hours; slow down. Cell signal drops near camp.

Did you know? — Lake Superior & the Northwoods

- **Lake Superior is the largest freshwater lake on Earth by surface area** — it holds about 10% of all the planet's surface fresh water and is so big it makes its own weather.

- It's also the **deepest** Great Lake (1,333 ft / 406 m) and the **third-largest lake in the world by volume** — enough water to flood all of North and South America a foot deep.
- Far out in the lake, **Isle Royale** hosts the **longest-running predator–prey study on Earth** (wolves and moose, since 1958); the moose swam ~15 miles to reach the island and the first wolves crossed on a winter ice bridge.
- Duluth is the **farthest-inland seaport in North America** — ocean ships sail 2,300+ miles to reach it from the Atlantic.
- You're crossing the **Iron Range**, where much of America's iron ore was mined for steel.
- Ely is the gateway to the **Boundary Waters**, home to the largest **wolf** population in the lower 48 states — plus moose, black bears, and loons.

Bear Head Lake SP, Site #2 · conf #12635093 · *MN park permit #12658950 covers this, Zippel Bay & Gooseberry*

Sat, Jun 27 — Bear Head Lake → Sioux Narrows Provincial Park, ON

~5 hr (≈230 mi) + border at International Falls / Fort Frances

Border: passports ready, no fresh produce/meat across.

Fuel/snacks: last Kwik Trip fill-up before Canada at International Falls (cheaper US-side, none in Ontario)

Lunch + quick photo: International Falls — lunch + the Smokey Bear statue before crossing

Dinner (takeout): Snackhouse Restaurant, Sioux Narrows (burgers, fries) — 807-226-9753. Backup: The Cornerstone.

Wild Things — Lake of the Woods & the Canadian Shield

- **American white pelican:** 9-ft wingspan, throat pouch holds 3 gallons; a line of them herds fish into the shallows to scoop. **Gross:** a chick eats by shoving its **whole head down the parent's throat** for regurgitated fish soup.
- **Muskie & walleye:** the muskie ("fish of 10,000 casts") is a toothy ambush predator that eats ducklings and other fish whole. Walleye have mirror-backed eyes that **glow and hunt in the dark**.
- **Snapping turtle:** too big to hide in its shell, so it bites — a beak that can take a finger. **Darker side:** it's the lake's cleanup crew, eating drowned and rotting animals off the bottom.
- **Jack pine:** its cones are glued shut with resin and only **pop open in a wildfire's heat** — the tree needs fire to reproduce.

⚠ Heads-up — border & remote Shield

- **Border:** passports out; no fresh produce, plants, or meat across. Fuel up US-side (cheaper, and gas/cell thin out in Ontario).
- Long remote stretches with little signal — top off the tank and download maps.
- Biting black flies and mosquitoes are at their worst now; bug spray + long sleeves at dusk.
- Watch for moose on the road through the Shield, especially low light.

Did you know? — The Border & Lake of the Woods

- International Falls is nicknamed the **"Icebox of the Nation"** for some of the coldest winter temperatures in the continental U.S.

- Crossing into Ontario, you roll onto the **Canadian Shield** — the **largest area of exposed Precambrian rock on Earth**, covering roughly **half of Canada**. Its bedrock runs up to a few **billion** years old; the Acasta Gneiss is **~4 billion**.
- The Shield's **Sudbury Basin** is a **1.85-billion-year-old meteorite crater** — the **second-largest impact structure on Earth**, visible from space — whose debris was flung as far as Minnesota. Apollo astronauts trained there, and it's now one of the world's great nickel-mining districts.
- **Lake of the Woods has 14,522 islands** — trace every island and the shoreline runs ~65,000 miles. **Sioux Narrows sits right on it**, and the lake's rocky shores hold ancient First Nations **pictographs** — some of the oldest rock art in Canada.
- Watch for **bald eagles, loons, and muskie** in these waters.

Sioux Narrows PP, Site #27 · conf INOP26-4271890B1

Sun, Jun 28 — Sioux Narrows → Tom & Carol's Cottage, Victoria Beach, MB

~3.5 hr (≈250 km), all within Canada (no border today)

Fuel/snacks: Petro-Canada / Esso (no Kwik Trip); Kenora on Hwy 17 has full services

Lunch (Kenora): Yesterday's Restaurant — big dog-friendly patio + takeout. Backup: Timber Garden (Keewatin). More: Visit Kenora.

Arrive cottage evening; stock up at Victoria Beach Grocery & General Store (111 Birch Ave, 8a–8p).

Dinner: first cottage night — cook in, or takeout from Le Gouter (seasonal).

Wild Things — where the forest becomes prairie

- **Red-sided garter snake:** a couple hours away near Narcisse is the **biggest snake gathering on the planet** — limestone pits holding tens of thousands. Each spring males swarm each female into a writhing "**mating ball.**" **Gross:** they give birth to live young (no eggs) and smear a foul musk on you when grabbed. By summer they've spread out to hunt frogs and worms.
- **Richardson's ground squirrel:** the "gophers" of the fields — they sleep through both the cold AND the hottest weeks, up to **9 months a year underground.**
- **Red-tailed hawk:** hunts the fields with eyesight ~8× sharper than yours.

⚠ Heads-up — arriving at Lake Winnipeg

- **Blue-green algae — biggest dog risk of the trip.** Lake Winnipeg blooms with toxic cyanobacteria in summer; **a tiny amount can kill a dog within hours, no antidote.** Before letting him near the water, check it's clear — no pea-soup green, scum, or paint-like streaks — and don't let him drink lakewater at the shoreline. Nearest 24-hr vet is in Winnipeg (~1.5 hr).
- Swimmer's itch can show up in warm shallows; towel off after swimming.
- Prairie thunderstorms build fast in the afternoon — keep an eye on the radar.

Did you know? — Victoria Beach & Lake Winnipeg

- Victoria Beach is the **only community in North America that bans private cars in July and August** — you park outside and walk, bike, or take a cab to the cottage.
- Its winter population of about **227 swells to roughly 10,000** people in summer.
- It sits on **Lake Winnipeg**, one of the **ten largest freshwater lakes in the world** — shallow, so it warms up nicely for swimming.

- You're crossing from rocky Canadian Shield into flat **prairie** — the bed of an Ice-Age lake bigger than all the Great Lakes combined.

Mon Jun 29 – Thu Jul 2 — Cottage, Victoria Beach, MB

Base camp — kitchen means cook most meals (pancakes still easy!).

Groceries: Victoria Beach store; bigger runs at Campbell's Foods, Lac du Bonnet.

Takeout / treats: Le Gouter, Village Green Bakery, Salty's Drive-Inn.

Day trips: beach days with the dog · The Forks, Winnipeg (~1.5 hr) · Whiteshell / Pinawa hikes.

Wild Things — lake, marsh & boreal forest

- **Great blue heron:** spears fish and swallows them whole, headfirst — sometimes you can watch a too-big lump slide down its neck. **Gross:** it blasts its poop backward away from the nest ("whitewash") and coughs up **pellets** of undigested bones and scales.
- **Wood frog:** survives winter by letting **two-thirds of its body freeze solid — heart stopped, not breathing** — then thaws alive in spring using sugar as antifreeze.
- **Leeches:** in the warm shallows. **Gross:** a leech has **three jaws and ~100 tiny teeth** and spit that stops blood from clotting so it can keep feeding (most lake leeches actually eat snails, not people — but check ankles after wading).
- **The rock:** the pink-and-gray Whiteshell granite is billion-year-old Shield bedrock flecked with sparkly quartz and dark-red garnet.

⚠ Heads-up — five days on the lake

- **Keep checking the water for algae** every beach day — blooms come and go with wind and heat. When in doubt, keep the dog out and rinse him if he's been in.
- Ticks in the Whiteshell woods (Lyme) — nightly checks on hikers and the dog.
- Black bears live in the Whiteshell — secure food and garbage at the cottage and on picnics.
- Long, intense sun on open water — sunscreen and shade, especially midday.

Did you know? — Manitoba

- **Winnie-the-Pooh is named after Winnipeg!** In 1914 a Canadian soldier, Harry Colebourn, bought a bear cub, named her "Winnie" after his hometown, and gave her to the London Zoo — where she inspired the stories.
- The nearby **Whiteshell** has ancient Indigenous **petroforms** — rocks laid out into shapes of snakes, turtles, and people, some thousands of years old.
- Winnipeg's **The Forks** has been a meeting place where two rivers join for **6,000+ years**.

- Manitoba is nicknamed the "**Land of 100,000 Lakes**" — even more lakes than Minnesota claims!

Fri, Jul 3 — Victoria Beach → Zippel Bay State Park, MN

~4 hr (~250 km) via Sprague → Warroad/Roseau

Fuel/snacks: first Kwik Trip back in the US at Warroad or Roseau

Lunch: Warroad or Roseau

Dinner (takeout): Lake of the Woods Pizza Company, Baudette. Fast backup: McDonald's/Subway in Baudette.

Wild Things — Zippel Bay & Lake of the Woods

- **Piping plover:** Zippel Bay's white-sand beach is one of only **four places in the region** this endangered shorebird still nests. When a predator nears the eggs, the parent fakes a **"broken wing,"** flopping away to lure it off, then flies away fine.
- **Sandhill crane:** nests on the bay's north side, stands 4+ ft tall, and **paints itself** by smearing rusty mud onto its feathers for camouflage. **Darker side:** it's an omnivore that stabs and eats ducklings, frogs, and rodents, and will raid other birds' nests for eggs. Its bugle carries 2.5 miles.
- **Also here:** white pelicans, bald eagles, river otters, and — in the woods — timber wolves and moose.

⚠ Heads-up — protected beach & border

- **Piping plover nesting:** stay out of posted/fenced beach zones and keep the dog leashed away from them — disturbing nests is illegal and the birds are barely hanging on.
- Border back into the US: passports, no produce/meat. Reset the dog's food plan after the crossing.
- Ticks in the grass-backed beach and woods — nightly checks.

Did you know? — Warroad, Roseau & Baudette

- **Lake of the Woods** — your campsite's lake — straddles **Minnesota, Ontario, and Manitoba** and is nicknamed **"the other Great Lake."** It averages just ~26 ft deep but plunges to **210 ft**.
- **Warroad is "Hockeytown USA"** — a tiny town that has sent players to multiple Olympics, and it's the home of Marvin Windows.
- **Roseau is the birthplace of the snowmobile** and of Polaris — every Polaris sled in the world is still assembled there.
- Baudette is the self-declared **"Walleye Capital of the World,"** guarded by **Willie the Walleye**, a 40-foot, 2½-ton fish statue.

- Just east is the **Northwest Angle** — the only piece of the lower-48 U.S. north of the Canada line, and you can only drive there **through Canada**.

Zippel Bay SP, Anglers Campground Site #48 · conf #12639147

Sat, Jul 4 — Zippel Bay → Gooseberry Falls State Park, MN

~4.5 hr (≈250 mi)

Fuel/snacks: Kwik Trip in Bemidji or Grand Rapids/Duluth

Lunch + cool stop: Bemidji — photo with Paul Bunyan & Babe, then eat on the road

Dinner (takeout): Black Woods Grill & Bar, Two Harbors, or Lake Superior Burger Co., Castle Danger. Sweet: Betty's Pies.

Wild Things — North Shore cliffs

- **Peregrine falcon:** nests on the North Shore's lava cliffs and is the **fastest animal alive** — it dives ("stoops") over **200 mph**, with bony cones in its nostrils so the wind doesn't blow its lungs apart. **Darker side:** it strikes prey in mid-air with a closed fist of talons and can knock the head clean off a pigeon, then plucks and eats it.
- **Lake Superior agate:** Minnesota's state gem — quartz that filled gas bubbles in the billion-year-old lava, then tumbled smooth by glaciers. Hunt the gravel beach at Gooseberry.
- **Black bear:** common all along the shore. **Gross:** its poop changes color with the season — dark from meat and bugs, then purple and seedy after gorging on berries.

⚠ Heads-up — July 4 on the North Shore

- **Lake Superior again:** cold-water shock + rip currents are deadly serious here — wade only, no swimming out, and watch the kids near the surf.
- **Waterfall edges:** Gooseberry's wet rock ledges are slick with no railings — keep kids back from the lip and the gorge.
- Holiday crowds = bolder, food-conditioned bears near busy campgrounds; lock up all food. Order dinner early.

Did you know? — Bemidji & the North Shore

- Bemidji calls itself the "**first city on the Mississippi River**" and built the giant **Paul Bunyan & Babe the Blue Ox** statues back in 1937.
- The North Shore's dramatic cliffs are ~**1.1-billion-year-old lava flows** from a time when North America almost ripped in half (the Midcontinent Rift).
- Scan the beaches for **Lake Superior agates** — Minnesota's state gemstone, banded red-and-white and polished by glaciers.
- Gooseberry Falls drops over those ancient lava ledges in a series of waterfalls you can walk right up to.

Gooseberry Falls SP, Site #68 · conf #12637943 · July 4 — order dinner early, North Shore is busy

Sun, Jul 5 — Gooseberry Falls → Brule River State Forest, WI

short day, ~1.5 hr (≈75 mi) — lots of slack for sightseeing

Cool stop (8 min from camp): Split Rock Lighthouse — iconic view, dog-friendly grounds + paved Gitchi-Gami Trail.

Fuel/snacks: big Kwik Trip selection in Duluth/Superior

Lunch: Duluth (Canal Park) or Superior

Dinner (takeout): Kro Bar & Grill, Brule; Culver's / A&W in Superior are dog-friendly fallbacks.

Wild Things — the Brule River

- **Brook trout:** the spring-fed Brule is ice-cold, which is exactly what trout need — they only survive in clean, cold, oxygen-rich water, so a healthy trout stream proves the water is pure.
- **Sea lamprey: the river-and-lake horror story** — an invasive jawless eel that clamps onto a fish with a suction mouth full of rasping teeth, files a hole, and **drinks its blood and body fluids** until the fish dies. It nearly wiped out Lake Superior's trout.
- **Crayfish:** the mini-lobsters under the rocks — they can **drop a claw to escape** and regrow it, and swim backward by flipping their tail.

⚠ Heads-up — cliffs & cold current

- **Split Rock cliff:** 130-ft drop with open, unfenced edges in spots — keep a hand on the kids near the overlooks.
- The Brule is a fast, cold river with real current — life jackets if anyone's near the water; it's not a wade-in swimming hole.
- Lake Superior shoreline at Duluth/Superior: still ~40°F and current-prone.

Did you know? — Split Rock & the Brule

- **Split Rock Lighthouse** was built because a single furious storm in November **1905 wrecked or damaged 29 ships** on Lake Superior in one night.
- Lake Superior's most famous wreck, the **Edmund Fitzgerald**, went down in a November storm in **1975** with all **29 hands** ("...the lake, it is said, never gives up her dead"). An estimated **550 shipwrecks** lie on the bottom, and the lake still holds the only **naturally self-sustaining lake-trout** population left in the Great Lakes.
- The **Brule River is the "River of Presidents"** — five U.S. presidents (Grant, Cleveland, Coolidge, Hoover, Eisenhower) fished here; **Coolidge ran his "Summer White House" from the Brule in 1928.**

- The spring-fed Brule drops **420 feet** on its way to Lake Superior, making lots of rapids — it's a famous trout and salmon river.

Brule River State Forest, Brule Campground · conf INWI26-1743772B1

Mon, Jul 6 — Brule River → Wisconsin Dells / Mirror Lake State Park

~4 hr (≈240 mi) south

Fuel/snacks: Kwik Trips all along the way

Lunch: Eau Claire or Tomah (or a second Norske Nook hit in Osseo!)

Afternoon: Wisconsin Dells (calendar has ~noon–6pm)

Dinner (takeout): Grateful Shed (dog-friendly food hall) or Brat House Grill. Patio: Ravina Bay.

Wild Things — Baraboo & the Dells gorge

- **Cranes:** nearby Baraboo has the **International Crane Foundation — the only place on Earth to see all 15 crane species**. The whooping crane dropped to about **15 birds alive in 1941**, and this place helped bring it back.
- **The gorge:** a 5-mile canyon of 500-million-year-old sandstone, blasted open ~15,000 years ago when a glacier-dammed lake burst and tore through in days.
- **Little brown bat:** eats up to **1,000 bugs an hour** by echolocation. **Darker side:** a fungus called white-nose syndrome has killed **millions** of these bats — it grows on their faces while they hibernate and starves them awake.

⚠ Heads-up — crowds, water & storms

- The Dells is packed in July — typical tourist-crowd stuff (watch the kids in the throngs, mind water-park hygiene and water safety).
- Severe afternoon thunderstorms are common in southern WI in summer — check radar before/after the water parks.
- **Mirror Lake construction (2026):** a road-construction project at the park may affect some campsites, the boat launch, and parking lots — confirm site access at check-in and watch for detours.
- Ticks in the Mirror Lake SP woods; quick check at camp.

Did you know? — Wisconsin Dells & Baraboo

- The "Dells" is a 5-mile gorge of **500-million-year-old sandstone**, carved when a glacial lake **burst its ice dam ~15,000 years ago** in a giant flood.
- The land is sacred to the **Ho-Chunk Nation**, whose ancient burial mounds remain nearby.
- Next-door **Baraboo is the birthplace of the Ringling Brothers Circus** (1884) — now the Circus World Museum with 260+ antique circus wagons.
- Wisconsin Dells is also the self-proclaimed **"Waterpark Capital of the World."**

Mirror Lake SP · conf INWI26-1744723B1 (check-in 3p)

Tue, Jul 7 — Mirror Lake → Home

~2.5 hr (≈170 mi) · checkout 1p

Fuel/snacks: one last Kwik Trip run for the road

Lunch: Madison for a real stop, or grab-and-go

Wild Things — prairie & farm country home

- **Sandhill crane:** flocks feed in southern Wisconsin's cut fields — one of the oldest bird types on Earth, barely changed in millions of years.
- **Turkey vulture:** the V-winged bird teetering over the highway finds carcasses by smell from a mile up. **Gross:** it **pees down its own legs to cool off** and **projectile-vomits** rotten slurry at attackers — and its stomach acid is strong enough to destroy anthrax, cholera, and botulism in the rotten meat it eats.
- **Home stretch:** the returning prairie is the flat bed of an ancient glacial lake — same story that started flattening out back in Manitoba.

⚠ Heads-up — last leg

- Summer storm season on the drive south — sudden downpours and crosswinds; build in buffer.
- Deer near dawn/dusk on the rural stretches before home.

Did you know? — Madison & home

- Wisconsin's capital, **Madison, is built on a narrow isthmus** — a skinny strip of land squeezed between two lakes, Mendota and Monona.
- The Wisconsin State Capitol dome is the **only granite dome in the U.S.** and, by law, no building downtown may be taller than it.
- Crossing back into Illinois, you're entering the **"Prairie State"** — almost home!

Quick notes

- **Kwik Trip** covers the entire US portion (WI + MN) — set for fuel and snacks except the Canada days.
- **Canada fuel:** Petro-Canada / Esso; stock up at the Victoria Beach store.
- **No gaps:** you reach the cottage Sun Jun 28 and stay through Jul 3 — every night covered.
- Dog-friendly picks favor takeout or patios; confirm seasonal hours by phone.
- Detours add little driving time. **Jul 5** is short — your best window for a longer wander (Split Rock + Duluth).
- **Pack for the safety list:** tick repellent + fine-tip tweezers, dog life jacket, leashes, sunscreen, a small first-aid kit, and a way to check water before the dog swims.
- **Fishing licenses:** if anyone casts a line, Minnesota, Wisconsin, and Ontario each require their **own** license (buy online before each leg). Lake of the Woods / Rainy River have special walleye limits — check current regs.
- **Firewood:** buy it at each park. You can't legally move firewood across state lines or the border — it spreads emerald ash borer and other tree-killing pests.

Glovebox cheat sheet

NIGHT	STAY	SITE	CONFIRMATION
Jun 25	Brunet Island SP	#39	INWI26-1293044B1
Jun 26	Bear Head Lake SP	#2	#12635093
Jun 27	Sioux Narrows PP	#27	INOP26-4271890B1
Jun 28–Jul 2	Cottage, Victoria Beach	5 nts	— private
Jul 3	Zippel Bay SP	Anglers #48	#12639147
Jul 4	Gooseberry Falls SP	#68	#12637943
Jul 5	Brule River SF	Brule	INWI26-1743772B1
Jul 6	Mirror Lake SP	—	INWI26-1744723B1

P MN vehicle permit: #12658950 (covers Bear Head, Zippel Bay, Gooseberry).

☎ Park offices: Brunet Island 715-239-6888 · Bear Head Lake 218-235-2520 · Zippel Bay 218-783-6252 · Gooseberry Falls 218-595-7100 · Mirror Lake 608-254-2333.

☎ Reservations: MN State Parks 866-857-2757 · Ontario Parks 1-888-668-7275.

🇺🇸 24-hr vets: Duluth/North Shore — BluePearl 218-302-8000 · Canada (ON+MB) — Winnipeg Animal Emergency 204-474-0298 · Dells — UW Veterinary Care (Madison) 608-263-7600.

Border quick-check: passports (all) · dog rabies certificate (both ways) + CDC Dog Import Form for US re-entry + microchip · no produce/meat/plants/firewood across · emergencies dial 911 (US & Canada).